

Assignment 2: Disparities in Policing

Data: California RIPA (Administrative Policing Records)

Go here: <https://openjustice.doj.ca.gov/data> (scroll till you see RIPA Data, get any year of your choosing and make sure you also get the README file so you know what the variables are.)

Format: PDF submission (must be generated using LaTeX/Overleaf) + Replication Code

Length: 3–4 pages (max)

1. Context and Summary Statistics

Select a specific jurisdiction (e.g., San Diego Police Department, Alameda, etc.) based on county or any geography that you want to explore (you might run into observational data issues if you pick a very small city/context, so just be reasonable about this).

- **Task:** Provide a table showing the total number of stops, the percentage of stops by race, and the reasons for the stops (not all reasons, pick a few that interest you).
- **Task:** Create a visualization showing the **Search Rate** (Searches / Total Stops) across different racial groups. (There might be a few definitions of “search” - with warrant, without warrant, with consent, without consent etc. - be specific, or create an aggregate “any search” variable from these).
- **Question:** Does a simple disparity in search rates prove discrimination? Why or why not?

2. The Veil of Darkness (VOD) Test

The VOD test assumes that police officers cannot easily identify a driver's race at night before making a stop. If the share of minority drivers stopped is higher during daylight than after dark, it would be consistent with racial profiling.

- **Task:** Estimate a regression where the dependent variable is an indicator for a Black/Hispanic driver being stopped and present your results in a table.
 - Key Variable: An indicator for "Daylight" (is it light or dark at the time of the stop?).
 - Constraint: You must control for the time of day (e.g., in 15-minute "bins") to ensure you aren't just picking up on different driving patterns at night. Focus on the margin of when the sun might be setting.
- **Question:** Does the probability of stopping a minority driver increase when the sun is up?

3. Becker's Outcome Test: Hit Rates

The Outcome Test focuses on the **success** of the search rather than the frequency. If officers have a lower "threshold of suspicion" for minority drivers, their searches of those drivers should be less productive (lower hit rates).

- **Task:** Compare the hit rate for White drivers vs. Black/Hispanic drivers. For this you would have to regress a dummy variable for whether contraband was found or not (this would be the dependent variable) on race (independent variables) while conditioning on a search occurring. Given that you already dealt with searches in the first part of this assignment, this should be relatively easy. Present your regression results in a table.
 - Key variable: Calculate the **Hit Rate** (Contraband Found / Total Searches) by race.
- **Question:** How different are search rates by race compared to hit rates? What does this tell you about the potential for disparate policing?

Implementation Notes:

All tables and figures should look professional and clean.